

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Transparency, RTI and Information Sharing - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Transparency, RTI and Information Sharing

TEN-SESSION CORE PATH • PRACTICE • OPTIONAL ADVANCED • REGISTER NOTES

1 Transparency, disclosure, information sharing, accountability and privacy

2 RTI foundations: rights-holder, public authority and existing records

3 Proactive disclosure, record management, open data and usable information

4 Request route: application, transfer, time limits, fees and assistance

5 Exemptions, harm, public-interest balancing and the twenty-year rule

6 Severability and third-party consultation without a disclosure veto

7 Appeals, burden of proof, remedies, penalties and excluded organisations

8 Information Commission independence and the RTI Amendment Act, 2019

9 Official secrecy, Puttaswamy privacy and the DPDP-RTI interface

10 Digital information sharing, PYQ routes and answer architecture

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Transparency, RTI and Information Sharing - Solved Practice Workbook

Generation: learner-v2:g1 **PYQ ownership:** Questions labelled as official reproduce the locally held UPSC GS-IV papers; routed historical demands are explicitly neutral renderings rather than invented quotations.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

MCQ 1

A department releases one contract only after litigation but keeps criteria and reasons routinely hidden. Which distinction prevents calling the whole institution transparent? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Transparency is the continuing institutional visibility of rules, criteria, reasons, records and results to appropriate scrutiny; one compelled disclosure may reveal information without changing an organisation's secrecy-oriented default.
- B. Disclosure is the release of specified information to a person or public, whether proactively or on request; it is an instrument of transparency but does not by itself create answerability, correction or consequence.
- C. Information sharing is the authorised movement of information between officials, institutions or persons for a defined function; unlike public disclosure, it may remain restricted and must respect necessity, accuracy, security and privacy.
- D. Accountability exists when an identified actor must explain conduct against a standard before a competent forum capable of judgment, correction, remedy or consequence; visibility is enabling evidence, not the completed relationship.

Answer: A

Explanation: Transparency is a systemic condition, not one isolated release is the controlling principle.

Transparency is the continuing institutional visibility of rules, criteria, reasons, records and results to appropriate scrutiny; one compelled disclosure may reveal information without changing an organisation's secrecy-oriented default. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 2

An agency regularly publishes decision criteria, reasons and outcomes in usable form. Which governance condition is being institutionalised? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Information sharing is the authorised movement of information between officials, institutions or persons for a defined function; unlike public disclosure, it may remain restricted and must respect necessity, accuracy, security and privacy.
- B. Transparency is the continuing institutional visibility of rules, criteria, reasons, records and results to appropriate scrutiny; one compelled disclosure may reveal information without changing an organisation's secrecy-oriented default.
- C. Accountability exists when an identified actor must explain conduct against a standard before a competent forum capable of judgment, correction, remedy or consequence; visibility is enabling evidence, not the completed relationship.
- D. Disclosure is the release of specified information to a person or public, whether proactively or on request; it is an instrument of transparency but does not by itself create answerability, correction or consequence.

Answer: B

Explanation: Transparency is a systemic condition, not one isolated release is the controlling principle.

Transparency is the continuing institutional visibility of rules, criteria, reasons, records and results to appropriate scrutiny; one compelled disclosure may reveal information without changing an organisation's secrecy-oriented default. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 3

A ministry supplies a requested file but no forum can examine the revealed irregularity. What has occurred without completing accountability? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Transparency is the continuing institutional visibility of rules, criteria, reasons, records and results to appropriate scrutiny; one compelled disclosure may reveal information without changing an organisation's secrecy-oriented default.
- B. Information sharing is the authorised movement of information between officials, institutions or persons for a defined function; unlike public disclosure, it may remain restricted and must respect necessity, accuracy, security and privacy.
- C. Disclosure is the release of specified information to a person or public, whether proactively or on request; it is an instrument of transparency but does not by itself create answerability, correction or consequence.
- D. Accountability exists when an identified actor must explain conduct against a standard before a competent forum capable of judgment, correction, remedy or consequence; visibility is enabling evidence, not the completed relationship.

Answer: C

Explanation: **Disclosure is a particular act of making information available** is the controlling principle. Disclosure is the release of specified information to a person or public, whether proactively or on request; it is an instrument of transparency but does not by itself create answerability, correction or consequence. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 4

A public authority uploads a sanctioned project report before any request. Which specific information act has occurred? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Information sharing is the authorised movement of information between officials, institutions or persons for a defined function; unlike public disclosure, it may remain restricted and must respect necessity, accuracy, security and privacy.
- B. Accountability exists when an identified actor must explain conduct against a standard before a competent forum capable of judgment, correction, remedy or consequence; visibility is enabling evidence, not the completed relationship.
- C. Transparency is the continuing institutional visibility of rules, criteria, reasons, records and results to appropriate scrutiny; one compelled disclosure may reveal information without changing an organisation's secrecy-oriented default.
- D. Disclosure is the release of specified information to a person or public, whether proactively or on request; it is an instrument of transparency but does not by itself create answerability, correction or consequence.

Answer: D

Explanation: **Disclosure is a particular act of making information available** is the controlling principle. Disclosure is the release of specified information to a person or public, whether proactively or on request; it is an instrument of transparency but does not by itself create answerability, correction or consequence. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 5

Two departments exchange the minimum verified beneficiary fields under lawful authority without publishing them. Which concept best describes the exchange? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Information sharing is the authorised movement of information between officials, institutions or persons for a defined function; unlike public disclosure, it may remain restricted and must respect necessity, accuracy, security and privacy.
- B. Transparency is the continuing institutional visibility of rules, criteria, reasons, records and results to appropriate scrutiny; one compelled disclosure may reveal information without changing an organisation's secrecy-oriented default.
- C. Disclosure is the release of specified information to a person or public, whether proactively or on request; it is an instrument of transparency but does not by itself create answerability, correction or consequence.
- D. Accountability exists when an identified actor must explain conduct against a standard before a competent forum capable of judgment, correction, remedy or consequence; visibility is enabling evidence, not the completed relationship.

Answer: A

Explanation: Information sharing is purpose-bound exchange, not automatic publication is the controlling principle. Information sharing is the authorised movement of information between officials, institutions or persons for a defined function; unlike public disclosure, it may remain restricted and must respect necessity, accuracy, security and privacy. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 6

An officer forwards an entire health database to an unrelated unit merely because both are governmental. Which purpose-bound limitation has failed? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Disclosure is the release of specified information to a person or public, whether proactively or on request; it is an instrument of transparency but does not by itself create answerability, correction or consequence.
- B. Information sharing is the authorised movement of information between officials, institutions or persons for a defined function; unlike public disclosure, it may remain restricted and must respect necessity, accuracy, security and privacy.
- C. Accountability exists when an identified actor must explain conduct against a standard before a competent forum capable of judgment, correction, remedy or consequence; visibility is enabling evidence, not the completed relationship.
- D. Transparency is the continuing institutional visibility of rules, criteria, reasons, records and results to appropriate scrutiny; one compelled disclosure may reveal information without changing an organisation's secrecy-oriented default.

Answer: B

Explanation: Information sharing is purpose-bound exchange, not automatic publication is the controlling principle. Information sharing is the authorised movement of information between officials, institutions or persons for a defined function; unlike public disclosure, it may remain restricted and must respect necessity, accuracy, security and privacy. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 7

An expenditure dashboard reveals delay but no officer must answer and no authority can correct it. Which governance element remains incomplete? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Transparency is the continuing institutional visibility of rules, criteria, reasons, records and results to appropriate scrutiny; one compelled disclosure may reveal information without changing an organisation's secrecy-oriented default.
- B. Disclosure is the release of specified information to a person or public, whether proactively or on request; it is an instrument of transparency but does not by itself create answerability, correction or consequence.
- C. Accountability exists when an identified actor must explain conduct against a standard before a competent forum capable of judgment, correction, remedy or consequence; visibility is enabling evidence, not the completed relationship.
- D. Information sharing is the authorised movement of information between officials, institutions or persons for a defined function; unlike public disclosure, it may remain restricted and must respect necessity, accuracy, security and privacy.

Answer: C

Explanation: Accountability requires answerability and a corrective forum is the controlling principle. Accountability exists when an identified actor must explain conduct against a standard before a competent forum capable of judgment, correction, remedy or consequence; visibility is enabling evidence, not the completed relationship. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 8

A review body examines disclosed reasons, orders correction and fixes responsibility. Which concept is fully operational? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Disclosure is the release of specified information to a person or public, whether proactively or on request; it is an instrument of transparency but does not by itself create answerability, correction or consequence.
- B. Information sharing is the authorised movement of information between officials, institutions or persons for a defined function; unlike public disclosure, it may remain restricted and must respect necessity, accuracy, security and privacy.
- C. Transparency is the continuing institutional visibility of rules, criteria, reasons, records and results to appropriate scrutiny; one compelled disclosure may reveal information without changing an organisation's secrecy-oriented default.
- D. Accountability exists when an identified actor must explain conduct against a standard before a competent forum capable of judgment, correction, remedy or consequence; visibility is enabling evidence, not the completed relationship.

Answer: D

Explanation: Accountability requires answerability and a corrective forum is the controlling principle. Accountability exists when an identified actor must explain conduct against a standard before a competent forum capable of judgment, correction, remedy or consequence; visibility is enabling evidence, not the completed relationship. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 9

A PIO rejects an Indian citizen solely for not proving personal loss from the requested contract. Which statutory starting point corrects the refusal? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The Right to Information Act confers the right to information on all citizens; applicants ordinarily need not establish a special interest, although access remains subject to the Act's defined scope and exemptions.
- B. The Act concerns information in material form held by or under the control of a public authority, including accessible private-body material under another law; it does not generally require creation of fresh opinions, analysis or answers.
- C. A request may be made in writing or electronically in English, Hindi or the area's official language; reasons cannot be demanded, assistance is due where needed, and a misdirected request must be transferred promptly.
- D. The ordinary RTI decision period is thirty days, life-or-liberty information is due within forty-eight hours, silence becomes deemed refusal, and information is free when the authority misses the statutory time limit.

Answer: A

Explanation: Section 3 creates a citizen's statutory right is the controlling principle. The Right to Information Act confers the right to information on all citizens; applicants ordinarily need not establish a special interest, although access remains subject to the Act's defined scope and exemptions. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 10

A foreign corporation claims Section 3 in its own right as though citizenship were irrelevant. Which limitation must be noticed? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A request may be made in writing or electronically in English, Hindi or the area's official language; reasons cannot be demanded, assistance is due where needed, and a misdirected request must be transferred promptly.
- B. The Right to Information Act confers the right to information on all citizens; applicants ordinarily need not establish a special interest, although access remains subject to the Act's defined scope and exemptions.
- C. The ordinary RTI decision period is thirty days, life-or-liberty information is due within forty-eight hours, silence becomes deemed refusal, and information is free when the authority misses the statutory time limit.
- D. The Act concerns information in material form held by or under the control of a public authority, including accessible private-body material under another law; it does not generally require creation of fresh opinions, analysis or answers.

Answer: B

Explanation: Section 3 creates a citizen's statutory right is the controlling principle. The Right to Information Act confers the right to information on all citizens; applicants ordinarily need not establish a special interest, although access remains subject to the Act's defined scope and exemptions. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 11

An applicant asks a PIO to invent a new economic forecast from raw files. Which boundary applies? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The Right to Information Act confers the right to information on all citizens; applicants ordinarily need not establish a special interest, although access remains subject to the Act's defined scope and exemptions.
- B. A request may be made in writing or electronically in English, Hindi or the area's official language; reasons cannot be demanded, assistance is due where needed, and a misdirected request must be transferred promptly.
- C. The Act concerns information in material form held by or under the control of a public authority, including accessible private-body material under another law; it does not generally require creation of fresh opinions, analysis or answers.
- D. The ordinary RTI decision period is thirty days, life-or-liberty information is due within forty-eight hours, silence becomes deemed refusal, and information is free when the authority misses the statutory time limit.

Answer: C

Explanation: RTI reaches existing material held or controlled, not new explanations is the controlling principle. The Act concerns information in material form held by or under the control of a public authority, including accessible private-body material under another law; it does not generally require creation of fresh opinions, analysis or answers. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 12

A regulator can lawfully access a licensee's inspection report under another statute. Which RTI scope principle may bring that existing report within reach? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A request may be made in writing or electronically in English, Hindi or the area's official language; reasons cannot be demanded, assistance is due where needed, and a misdirected request must be transferred promptly.
- B. The ordinary RTI decision period is thirty days, life-or-liberty information is due within forty-eight hours, silence becomes deemed refusal, and information is free when the authority misses the statutory time limit.
- C. The Right to Information Act confers the right to information on all citizens; applicants ordinarily need not establish a special interest, although access remains subject to the Act's defined scope and exemptions.
- D. The Act concerns information in material form held by or under the control of a public authority, including accessible private-body material under another law; it does not generally require creation of fresh opinions, analysis or answers.

Answer: D

Explanation: RTI reaches existing material held or controlled, not new explanations is the controlling principle. The Act concerns information in material form held by or under the control of a public authority, including accessible private-body material under another law; it does not generally require creation of fresh opinions, analysis or answers. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 13

A PIO insists that an applicant reveal why she wants expenditure vouchers. Which Section 6 safeguard is violated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A request may be made in writing or electronically in English, Hindi or the area's official language; reasons cannot be demanded, assistance is due where needed, and a misdirected request must be transferred promptly.
- B. The Right to Information Act confers the right to information on all citizens; applicants ordinarily need not establish a special interest, although access remains subject to the Act's defined scope and exemptions.
- C. The Act concerns information in material form held by or under the control of a public authority, including accessible private-body material under another law; it does not generally require creation of fresh opinions, analysis or answers.
- D. The ordinary RTI decision period is thirty days, life-or-liberty information is due within forty-eight hours, silence becomes deemed refusal, and information is free when the authority misses the statutory time limit.

Answer: A

Explanation: **Section 6 minimises applicant burden and requires transfer** is the controlling principle. A request may be made in writing or electronically in English, Hindi or the area's official language; reasons cannot be demanded, assistance is due where needed, and a misdirected request must be transferred promptly. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 14

The requested record is held by another public authority and the application is transferred with notice. Which statutory route is illustrated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The Act concerns information in material form held by or under the control of a public authority, including accessible private-body material under another law; it does not generally require creation of fresh opinions, analysis or answers.
- B. A request may be made in writing or electronically in English, Hindi or the area's official language; reasons cannot be demanded, assistance is due where needed, and a misdirected request must be transferred promptly.
- C. The ordinary RTI decision period is thirty days, life-or-liberty information is due within forty-eight hours, silence becomes deemed refusal, and information is free when the authority misses the statutory time limit.
- D. The Right to Information Act confers the right to information on all citizens; applicants ordinarily need not establish a special interest, although access remains subject to the Act's defined scope and exemptions.

Answer: B

Explanation: **Section 6 minimises applicant burden and requires transfer** is the controlling principle. A request may be made in writing or electronically in English, Hindi or the area's official language; reasons cannot be demanded, assistance is due where needed, and a misdirected request must be transferred promptly. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 15

A life-saving drug record is withheld for the ordinary thirty-day period despite a demonstrated life-or-liberty nexus. Which timeline applies? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The Right to Information Act confers the right to information on all citizens; applicants ordinarily need not establish a special interest, although access remains subject to the Act's defined scope and exemptions.
- B. The Act concerns information in material form held by or under the control of a public authority, including accessible private-body material under another law; it does not generally require creation of fresh opinions, analysis or answers.
- C. The ordinary RTI decision period is thirty days, life-or-liberty information is due within forty-eight hours, silence becomes deemed refusal, and information is free when the authority misses the statutory time limit.
- D. A request may be made in writing or electronically in English, Hindi or the area's official language; reasons cannot be demanded, assistance is due where needed, and a misdirected request must be transferred promptly.

Answer: C

Explanation: Section 7 combines ordinary, urgent and deemed-refusal timelines is the controlling principle. The ordinary RTI decision period is thirty days, life-or-liberty information is due within forty-eight hours, silence becomes deemed refusal, and information is free when the authority misses the statutory time limit. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 16

A PIO gives no decision until after the statutory period and then demands the normal access fee. Which consequence should be considered? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The Act concerns information in material form held by or under the control of a public authority, including accessible private-body material under another law; it does not generally require creation of fresh opinions, analysis or answers.
- B. A request may be made in writing or electronically in English, Hindi or the area's official language; reasons cannot be demanded, assistance is due where needed, and a misdirected request must be transferred promptly.
- C. The Right to Information Act confers the right to information on all citizens; applicants ordinarily need not establish a special interest, although access remains subject to the Act's defined scope and exemptions.
- D. The ordinary RTI decision period is thirty days, life-or-liberty information is due within forty-eight hours, silence becomes deemed refusal, and information is free when the authority misses the statutory time limit.

Answer: D

Explanation: Section 7 combines ordinary, urgent and deemed-refusal timelines is the controlling principle. The ordinary RTI decision period is thirty days, life-or-liberty information is due within forty-eight hours, silence becomes deemed refusal, and information is free when the authority misses the statutory time limit. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 17

A department receives thousands of identical applications for already digitised subsidy criteria. Which statutory strategy should be strengthened first? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. RTI requires organised records and specified suo motu publication, with a constant endeavour to provide information proactively so citizens need minimum resort to individual requests.
- B. Proactive transparency requires current, searchable, accessible and intelligible information, not merely scanned dumps or obsolete links; publication without findability, context, disability access or timely updating can become compliance theatre.
- C. Open data emphasises reusable, often machine-readable public datasets, whereas RTI can also secure records, reasons and correspondence not suitable for open release; both remain bounded by lawful confidentiality, security and privacy.
- D. Digitisation can improve search, time stamps, audit trails and simultaneous access, yet poor indexing context, deletion, vendor lock-in, manipulated logs, cyber insecurity and inaccessible interfaces can reproduce opacity electronically.

Answer: A

Explanation: Section 4 makes proactive disclosure the first transparency channel is the controlling principle. RTI requires organised records and specified suo motu publication, with a constant endeavour to provide information proactively so citizens need minimum resort to individual requests. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 18

A ministry publishes functions, decision norms, budget and subsidy details before any request. Which RTI architecture is operating? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Open data emphasises reusable, often machine-readable public datasets, whereas RTI can also secure records, reasons and correspondence not suitable for open release; both remain bounded by lawful confidentiality, security and privacy.
- B. RTI requires organised records and specified suo motu publication, with a constant endeavour to provide information proactively so citizens need minimum resort to individual requests.
- C. Digitisation can improve search, time stamps, audit trails and simultaneous access, yet poor indexing context, deletion, vendor lock-in, manipulated logs, cyber insecurity and inaccessible interfaces can reproduce opacity electronically.
- D. Proactive transparency requires current, searchable, accessible and intelligible information, not merely scanned dumps or obsolete links; publication without findability, context, disability access or timely updating can become compliance theatre.

Answer: B

Explanation: Section 4 makes proactive disclosure the first transparency channel is the controlling principle. RTI requires organised records and specified suo motu publication, with a constant endeavour to provide information proactively so citizens need minimum resort to individual requests. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 19

A website uploads thousands of unsearchable image files without dates or headings. Which quality dimension of transparency is missing? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. RTI requires organised records and specified suo motu publication, with a constant endeavour to provide information proactively so citizens need minimum resort to individual requests.
- B. Open data emphasises reusable, often machine-readable public datasets, whereas RTI can also secure records, reasons and correspondence not suitable for open release; both remain bounded by lawful confidentiality, security and privacy.
- C. Proactive transparency requires current, searchable, accessible and intelligible information, not merely scanned dumps or obsolete links; publication without findability, context, disability access or timely updating can become compliance theatre.
- D. Digitisation can improve search, time stamps, audit trails and simultaneous access, yet poor indexing context, deletion, vendor lock-in, manipulated logs, cyber insecurity and inaccessible interfaces can reproduce opacity electronically.

Answer: C

Explanation: Usability matters alongside publication is the controlling principle. Proactive transparency requires current, searchable, accessible and intelligible information, not merely scanned dumps or obsolete links; publication without findability, context, disability access or timely updating can become compliance theatre. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 20

A portal offers machine-readable data, plain-language metadata, accessible formats and update dates. Which ethical improvement is demonstrated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Open data emphasises reusable, often machine-readable public datasets, whereas RTI can also secure records, reasons and correspondence not suitable for open release; both remain bounded by lawful confidentiality, security and privacy.
- B. Digitisation can improve search, time stamps, audit trails and simultaneous access, yet poor indexing context, deletion, vendor lock-in, manipulated logs, cyber insecurity and inaccessible interfaces can reproduce opacity electronically.
- C. RTI requires organised records and specified suo motu publication, with a constant endeavour to provide information proactively so citizens need minimum resort to individual requests.
- D. Proactive transparency requires current, searchable, accessible and intelligible information, not merely scanned dumps or obsolete links; publication without findability, context, disability access or timely updating can become compliance theatre.

Answer: D

Explanation: Usability matters alongside publication is the controlling principle. Proactive transparency requires current, searchable, accessible and intelligible information, not merely scanned dumps or obsolete links; publication without findability, context, disability access or timely updating can become compliance theatre. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 21

A candidate claims a statistical open-data portal eliminates the need for access to recorded reasons. Which distinction corrects the claim? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Open data emphasises reusable, often machine-readable public datasets, whereas RTI can also secure records, reasons and correspondence not suitable for open release; both remain bounded by lawful confidentiality, security and privacy.
- B. RTI requires organised records and specified suo motu publication, with a constant endeavour to provide information proactively so citizens need minimum resort to individual requests.
- C. Proactive transparency requires current, searchable, accessible and intelligible information, not merely scanned dumps or obsolete links; publication without findability, context, disability access or timely updating can become compliance theatre.
- D. Digitisation can improve search, time stamps, audit trails and simultaneous access, yet poor indexing context, deletion, vendor lock-in, manipulated logs, cyber insecurity and inaccessible interfaces can reproduce opacity electronically.

Answer: A

Explanation: **Open data and RTI overlap but are not identical** is the controlling principle. Open data emphasises reusable, often machine-readable public datasets, whereas RTI can also secure records, reasons and correspondence not suitable for open release; both remain bounded by lawful confidentiality, security and privacy. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 22

A city releases anonymised transport data for reuse while retaining a request route for file-level decisions. Which complementary design is shown? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Proactive transparency requires current, searchable, accessible and intelligible information, not merely scanned dumps or obsolete links; publication without findability, context, disability access or timely updating can become compliance theatre.
- B. Open data emphasises reusable, often machine-readable public datasets, whereas RTI can also secure records, reasons and correspondence not suitable for open release; both remain bounded by lawful confidentiality, security and privacy.
- C. Digitisation can improve search, time stamps, audit trails and simultaneous access, yet poor indexing context, deletion, vendor lock-in, manipulated logs, cyber insecurity and inaccessible interfaces can reproduce opacity electronically.
- D. RTI requires organised records and specified suo motu publication, with a constant endeavour to provide information proactively so citizens need minimum resort to individual requests.

Answer: B

Explanation: **Open data and RTI overlap but are not identical** is the controlling principle. Open data emphasises reusable, often machine-readable public datasets, whereas RTI can also secure records, reasons and correspondence not suitable for open release; both remain bounded by lawful confidentiality, security and privacy. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 23

A department scans files but cannot search, authenticate or preserve versions. Why has digitisation not ensured transparency? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. RTI requires organised records and specified suo motu publication, with a constant endeavour to provide information proactively so citizens need minimum resort to individual requests.
- B. Proactive transparency requires current, searchable, accessible and intelligible information, not merely scanned dumps or obsolete links; publication without findability, context, disability access or timely updating can become compliance theatre.
- C. Digitisation can improve search, time stamps, audit trails and simultaneous access, yet poor indexing context, deletion, vendor lock-in, manipulated logs, cyber insecurity and inaccessible interfaces can reproduce opacity electronically.
- D. Open data emphasises reusable, often machine-readable public datasets, whereas RTI can also secure records, reasons and correspondence not suitable for open release; both remain bounded by lawful confidentiality, security and privacy.

Answer: C

Explanation: Digital records can reduce opacity but preserve new risks is the controlling principle. Digitisation can improve search, time stamps, audit trails and simultaneous access, yet poor indexing context, deletion, vendor lock-in, manipulated logs, cyber insecurity and inaccessible interfaces can reproduce opacity electronically. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 24

A records system preserves provenance, retention schedules, access logs and exportable formats. Which enabling architecture is strengthened? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Proactive transparency requires current, searchable, accessible and intelligible information, not merely scanned dumps or obsolete links; publication without findability, context, disability access or timely updating can become compliance theatre.
- B. Open data emphasises reusable, often machine-readable public datasets, whereas RTI can also secure records, reasons and correspondence not suitable for open release; both remain bounded by lawful confidentiality, security and privacy.
- C. RTI requires organised records and specified suo motu publication, with a constant endeavour to provide information proactively so citizens need minimum resort to individual requests.
- D. Digitisation can improve search, time stamps, audit trails and simultaneous access, yet poor indexing context, deletion, vendor lock-in, manipulated logs, cyber insecurity and inaccessible interfaces can reproduce opacity electronically.

Answer: D

Explanation: Digital records can reduce opacity but preserve new risks is the controlling principle. Digitisation can improve search, time stamps, audit trails and simultaneous access, yet poor indexing context, deletion, vendor lock-in, manipulated logs, cyber insecurity and inaccessible interfaces can reproduce opacity electronically. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 25

A PIO writes only 'confidential' without identifying a statutory harm or clause. Which exemption discipline is absent? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. RTI exemptions protect defined interests such as security, judicial restrictions, legislative privilege, commercial confidence, fiduciary information, safety, investigation, cabinet material and personal information; withholding needs clause-linked reasoning.
- B. The statutory public-interest override permits access despite official-secrecy law or listed exemptions where disclosure benefit outweighs harm to protected interests; it requires a reasoned balance, not an automatic presumption.
- C. Where an exempt part can reasonably be separated from the remainder, severability requires access to the non-exempt record with notice of reasons, decision-maker, fee and review rights rather than blanket withholding.
- D. Confidential third-party material triggers notice and consideration, but the PIO makes the reasoned decision subject to public-interest and appeal rules; the third party does not possess an absolute veto.

Answer: A

Explanation: Section 8 exemptions are specific protections, not a secrecy slogan is the controlling principle. RTI exemptions protect defined interests such as security, judicial restrictions, legislative privilege, commercial confidence, fiduciary information, safety, investigation, cabinet material and personal information; withholding needs clause-linked reasoning. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 26

Disclosure would reveal a protected source and endanger that person's safety. Which kind of Section 8 interest is legitimately engaged? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Where an exempt part can reasonably be separated from the remainder, severability requires access to the non-exempt record with notice of reasons, decision-maker, fee and review rights rather than blanket withholding.
- B. RTI exemptions protect defined interests such as security, judicial restrictions, legislative privilege, commercial confidence, fiduciary information, safety, investigation, cabinet material and personal information; withholding needs clause-linked reasoning.
- C. Confidential third-party material triggers notice and consideration, but the PIO makes the reasoned decision subject to public-interest and appeal rules; the third party does not possess an absolute veto.
- D. The statutory public-interest override permits access despite official-secrecy law or listed exemptions where disclosure benefit outweighs harm to protected interests; it requires a reasoned balance, not an automatic presumption.

Answer: B

Explanation: Section 8 exemptions are specific protections, not a secrecy slogan is the controlling principle. RTI exemptions protect defined interests such as security, judicial restrictions, legislative privilege, commercial confidence, fiduciary information, safety, investigation, cabinet material and personal information; withholding needs clause-linked reasoning. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 27

Evidence of serious public harm is requested, but disclosure also creates a concrete protected risk. Which statutory balance must the authority perform? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. RTI exemptions protect defined interests such as security, judicial restrictions, legislative privilege, commercial confidence, fiduciary information, safety, investigation, cabinet material and personal information; withholding needs clause-linked reasoning.
- B. Where an exempt part can reasonably be separated from the remainder, severability requires access to the non-exempt record with notice of reasons, decision-maker, fee and review rights rather than blanket withholding.
- C. The statutory public-interest override permits access despite official-secrecy law or listed exemptions where disclosure benefit outweighs harm to protected interests; it requires a reasoned balance, not an automatic presumption.
- D. Confidential third-party material triggers notice and consideration, but the PIO makes the reasoned decision subject to public-interest and appeal rules; the third party does not possess an absolute veto.

Answer: C

Explanation: Section 8(2) retains a statutory public-interest override is the controlling principle. The statutory public-interest override permits access despite official-secrecy law or listed exemptions where disclosure benefit outweighs harm to protected interests; it requires a reasoned balance, not an automatic presumption. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 28

An applicant asserts that uttering 'public interest' automatically defeats every exemption. Which qualification corrects the claim? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Where an exempt part can reasonably be separated from the remainder, severability requires access to the non-exempt record with notice of reasons, decision-maker, fee and review rights rather than blanket withholding.
- B. Confidential third-party material triggers notice and consideration, but the PIO makes the reasoned decision subject to public-interest and appeal rules; the third party does not possess an absolute veto.
- C. RTI exemptions protect defined interests such as security, judicial restrictions, legislative privilege, commercial confidence, fiduciary information, safety, investigation, cabinet material and personal information; withholding needs clause-linked reasoning.
- D. The statutory public-interest override permits access despite official-secrecy law or listed exemptions where disclosure benefit outweighs harm to protected interests; it requires a reasoned balance, not an automatic presumption.

Answer: D

Explanation: Section 8(2) retains a statutory public-interest override is the controlling principle. The statutory public-interest override permits access despite official-secrecy law or listed exemptions where disclosure benefit outweighs harm to protected interests; it requires a reasoned balance, not an automatic presumption. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 29

Only two names in a long inspection report require lawful protection, yet the entire report is denied. Which statutory technique was omitted? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Where an exempt part can reasonably be separated from the remainder, severability requires access to the non-exempt record with notice of reasons, decision-maker, fee and review rights rather than blanket withholding.
- B. RTI exemptions protect defined interests such as security, judicial restrictions, legislative privilege, commercial confidence, fiduciary information, safety, investigation, cabinet material and personal information; withholding needs clause-linked reasoning.
- C. The statutory public-interest override permits access despite official-secrecy law or listed exemptions where disclosure benefit outweighs harm to protected interests; it requires a reasoned balance, not an automatic presumption.
- D. Confidential third-party material triggers notice and consideration, but the PIO makes the reasoned decision subject to public-interest and appeal rules; the third party does not possess an absolute veto.

Answer: A

Explanation: Section 10 requires severability is the controlling principle. Where an exempt part can reasonably be separated from the remainder, severability requires access to the non-exempt record with notice of reasons, decision-maker, fee and review rights rather than blanket withholding. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 30

A PIO redacts protected identifiers and releases the remaining findings with appeal details. Which principle is applied? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The statutory public-interest override permits access despite official-secrecy law or listed exemptions where disclosure benefit outweighs harm to protected interests; it requires a reasoned balance, not an automatic presumption.
- B. Where an exempt part can reasonably be separated from the remainder, severability requires access to the non-exempt record with notice of reasons, decision-maker, fee and review rights rather than blanket withholding.
- C. Confidential third-party material triggers notice and consideration, but the PIO makes the reasoned decision subject to public-interest and appeal rules; the third party does not possess an absolute veto.
- D. RTI exemptions protect defined interests such as security, judicial restrictions, legislative privilege, commercial confidence, fiduciary information, safety, investigation, cabinet material and personal information; withholding needs clause-linked reasoning.

Answer: B

Explanation: Section 10 requires severability is the controlling principle. Where an exempt part can reasonably be separated from the remainder, severability requires access to the non-exempt record with notice of reasons, decision-maker, fee and review rights rather than blanket withholding. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 31

A contractor objects to release and the PIO treats objection as automatically conclusive. Which procedural misconception is present? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. RTI exemptions protect defined interests such as security, judicial restrictions, legislative privilege, commercial confidence, fiduciary information, safety, investigation, cabinet material and personal information; withholding needs clause-linked reasoning.
- B. The statutory public-interest override permits access despite official-secrecy law or listed exemptions where disclosure benefit outweighs harm to protected interests; it requires a reasoned balance, not an automatic presumption.
- C. Confidential third-party material triggers notice and consideration, but the PIO makes the reasoned decision subject to public-interest and appeal rules; the third party does not possess an absolute veto.
- D. Where an exempt part can reasonably be separated from the remainder, severability requires access to the non-exempt record with notice of reasons, decision-maker, fee and review rights rather than blanket withholding.

Answer: C

Explanation: Section 11 is consultation, not a third-party veto is the controlling principle. Confidential third-party material triggers notice and consideration, but the PIO makes the reasoned decision subject to public-interest and appeal rules; the third party does not possess an absolute veto. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 32

The PIO notifies the contractor, considers its representation and independently decides disclosure with appeal notice. Which procedure is correctly followed? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The statutory public-interest override permits access despite official-secrecy law or listed exemptions where disclosure benefit outweighs harm to protected interests; it requires a reasoned balance, not an automatic presumption.
- B. Where an exempt part can reasonably be separated from the remainder, severability requires access to the non-exempt record with notice of reasons, decision-maker, fee and review rights rather than blanket withholding.
- C. RTI exemptions protect defined interests such as security, judicial restrictions, legislative privilege, commercial confidence, fiduciary information, safety, investigation, cabinet material and personal information; withholding needs clause-linked reasoning.
- D. Confidential third-party material triggers notice and consideration, but the PIO makes the reasoned decision subject to public-interest and appeal rules; the third party does not possess an absolute veto.

Answer: D

Explanation: Section 11 is consultation, not a third-party veto is the controlling principle. Confidential third-party material triggers notice and consideration, but the PIO makes the reasoned decision subject to public-interest and appeal rules; the third party does not possess an absolute veto. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 33

An appellate authority tells the citizen alone to prove that secrecy was unlawful. Which burden rule has been reversed? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. RTI provides a first appeal within the public authority and a second appeal to the Information Commission; in appeal proceedings the burden of proving that denial was justified lies on the denying PIO.
- B. The Information Commission may impose two hundred and fifty rupees per day up to twenty-five thousand rupees for specified PIO failures after hearing, unless reasonable and diligent conduct is proved; persistent default may support disciplinary recommendation.
- C. Specified intelligence and security organisations are generally excluded, but information concerning allegations of corruption or human-rights violations is not wholly outside the Act; human-rights disclosure follows Commission approval and a special timeline.
- D. The RTI Amendment Act, 2019 replaced Parliament-fixed tenure and salary links for Central and State Information Commissioners with terms prescribed by the Central Government; the 2019 Rules prescribe a three-year term, subject to the age ceiling.

Answer: A

Explanation: Section 19 makes the PIO justify denial is the controlling principle. RTI provides a first appeal within the public authority and a second appeal to the Information Commission; in appeal proceedings the burden of proving that denial was justified lies on the denying PIO. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 34

A first appellate authority reviews the PIO's reasons before a later Commission appeal. Which two-stage appellate structure is illustrated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Specified intelligence and security organisations are generally excluded, but information concerning allegations of corruption or human-rights violations is not wholly outside the Act; human-rights disclosure follows Commission approval and a special timeline.
- B. RTI provides a first appeal within the public authority and a second appeal to the Information Commission; in appeal proceedings the burden of proving that denial was justified lies on the denying PIO.
- C. The RTI Amendment Act, 2019 replaced Parliament-fixed tenure and salary links for Central and State Information Commissioners with terms prescribed by the Central Government; the 2019 Rules prescribe a three-year term, subject to the age ceiling.
- D. The Information Commission may impose two hundred and fifty rupees per day up to twenty-five thousand rupees for specified PIO failures after hearing, unless reasonable and diligent conduct is proved; persistent default may support disciplinary recommendation.

Answer: B

Explanation: Section 19 makes the PIO justify denial is the controlling principle. RTI provides a first appeal within the public authority and a second appeal to the Information Commission; in appeal proceedings the burden of proving that denial was justified lies on the denying PIO. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 35

A note says every delayed reply automatically fines the department without hearing. Which penalty qualifications are missing? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. RTI provides a first appeal within the public authority and a second appeal to the Information Commission; in appeal proceedings the burden of proving that denial was justified lies on the denying PIO.
- B. Specified intelligence and security organisations are generally excluded, but information concerning allegations of corruption or human-rights violations is not wholly outside the Act; human-rights disclosure follows Commission approval and a special timeline.
- C. The Information Commission may impose two hundred and fifty rupees per day up to twenty-five thousand rupees for specified PIO failures after hearing, unless reasonable and diligent conduct is proved; persistent default may support disciplinary recommendation.
- D. The RTI Amendment Act, 2019 replaced Parliament-fixed tenure and salary links for Central and State Information Commissioners with terms prescribed by the Central Government; the 2019 Rules prescribe a three-year term, subject to the age ceiling.

Answer: C

Explanation: Section 20 penalty is personal, conditional and capped is the controlling principle. The Information Commission may impose two hundred and fifty rupees per day up to twenty-five thousand rupees for specified PIO failures after hearing, unless reasonable and diligent conduct is proved; persistent default may support disciplinary recommendation. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 36

A PIO knowingly destroys requested information and cannot show reasonable diligence. Which Section 20 consequence may arise? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Specified intelligence and security organisations are generally excluded, but information concerning allegations of corruption or human-rights violations is not wholly outside the Act; human-rights disclosure follows Commission approval and a special timeline.
- B. The RTI Amendment Act, 2019 replaced Parliament-fixed tenure and salary links for Central and State Information Commissioners with terms prescribed by the Central Government; the 2019 Rules prescribe a three-year term, subject to the age ceiling.
- C. RTI provides a first appeal within the public authority and a second appeal to the Information Commission; in appeal proceedings the burden of proving that denial was justified lies on the denying PIO.
- D. The Information Commission may impose two hundred and fifty rupees per day up to twenty-five thousand rupees for specified PIO failures after hearing, unless reasonable and diligent conduct is proved; persistent default may support disciplinary recommendation.

Answer: D

Explanation: Section 20 penalty is personal, conditional and capped is the controlling principle. The Information Commission may impose two hundred and fifty rupees per day up to twenty-five thousand rupees for specified PIO failures after hearing, unless reasonable and diligent conduct is proved; persistent default may support disciplinary recommendation. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 37

An authority claims a Second Schedule organisation can never face any RTI request. Which exceptions defeat the absolute proposition? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Specified intelligence and security organisations are generally excluded, but information concerning allegations of corruption or human-rights violations is not wholly outside the Act; human-rights disclosure follows Commission approval and a special timeline.
- B. RTI provides a first appeal within the public authority and a second appeal to the Information Commission; in appeal proceedings the burden of proving that denial was justified lies on the denying PIO.
- C. The Information Commission may impose two hundred and fifty rupees per day up to twenty-five thousand rupees for specified PIO failures after hearing, unless reasonable and diligent conduct is proved; persistent default may support disciplinary recommendation.
- D. The RTI Amendment Act, 2019 replaced Parliament-fixed tenure and salary links for Central and State Information Commissioners with terms prescribed by the Central Government; the 2019 Rules prescribe a three-year term, subject to the age ceiling.

Answer: A

Explanation: Section 24 exclusion has corruption and human-rights exceptions is the controlling principle. Specified intelligence and security organisations are generally excluded, but information concerning allegations of corruption or human-rights violations is not wholly outside the Act; human-rights disclosure follows Commission approval and a special timeline. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 38

A human-rights allegation involving an excluded organisation is routed for the required Commission approval. Which special architecture is engaged? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The Information Commission may impose two hundred and fifty rupees per day up to twenty-five thousand rupees for specified PIO failures after hearing, unless reasonable and diligent conduct is proved; persistent default may support disciplinary recommendation.
- B. Specified intelligence and security organisations are generally excluded, but information concerning allegations of corruption or human-rights violations is not wholly outside the Act; human-rights disclosure follows Commission approval and a special timeline.
- C. The RTI Amendment Act, 2019 replaced Parliament-fixed tenure and salary links for Central and State Information Commissioners with terms prescribed by the Central Government; the 2019 Rules prescribe a three-year term, subject to the age ceiling.
- D. RTI provides a first appeal within the public authority and a second appeal to the Information Commission; in appeal proceedings the burden of proving that denial was justified lies on the denying PIO.

Answer: B

Explanation: Section 24 exclusion has corruption and human-rights exceptions is the controlling principle. Specified intelligence and security organisations are generally excluded, but information concerning allegations of corruption or human-rights violations is not wholly outside the Act; human-rights disclosure follows Commission approval and a special timeline. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 39

A candidate says the Amendment itself wrote 'three years' into Sections 13 and 16. Which statute-versus-rule distinction corrects the answer? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. RTI provides a first appeal within the public authority and a second appeal to the Information Commission; in appeal proceedings the burden of proving that denial was justified lies on the denying PIO.
- B. The Information Commission may impose two hundred and fifty rupees per day up to twenty-five thousand rupees for specified PIO failures after hearing, unless reasonable and diligent conduct is proved; persistent default may support disciplinary recommendation.
- C. The RTI Amendment Act, 2019 replaced Parliament-fixed tenure and salary links for Central and State Information Commissioners with terms prescribed by the Central Government; the 2019 Rules prescribe a three-year term, subject to the age ceiling.
- D. Specified intelligence and security organisations are generally excluded, but information concerning allegations of corruption or human-rights violations is not wholly outside the Act; human-rights disclosure follows Commission approval and a special timeline.

Answer: C

Explanation: The 2019 amendment shifted service-condition detail to rules is the controlling principle. The RTI Amendment Act, 2019 replaced Parliament-fixed tenure and salary links for Central and State Information Commissioners with terms prescribed by the Central Government; the 2019 Rules prescribe a three-year term, subject to the age ceiling. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 40

A critic focuses on executive rule-making over watchdog tenure rather than abolition of RTI rights. Which institutional issue is being identified? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The Information Commission may impose two hundred and fifty rupees per day up to twenty-five thousand rupees for specified PIO failures after hearing, unless reasonable and diligent conduct is proved; persistent default may support disciplinary recommendation.
- B. Specified intelligence and security organisations are generally excluded, but information concerning allegations of corruption or human-rights violations is not wholly outside the Act; human-rights disclosure follows Commission approval and a special timeline.
- C. RTI provides a first appeal within the public authority and a second appeal to the Information Commission; in appeal proceedings the burden of proving that denial was justified lies on the denying PIO.
- D. The RTI Amendment Act, 2019 replaced Parliament-fixed tenure and salary links for Central and State Information Commissioners with terms prescribed by the Central Government; the 2019 Rules prescribe a three-year term, subject to the age ceiling.

Answer: D

Explanation: The 2019 amendment shifted service-condition detail to rules is the controlling principle. The RTI Amendment Act, 2019 replaced Parliament-fixed tenure and salary links for Central and State Information Commissioners with terms prescribed by the Central Government; the 2019 Rules prescribe a three-year term, subject to the age ceiling. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 41

A department invokes the OSA label alone and refuses to examine Sections 8 and 10. Which interface rule is ignored? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The RTI Act overrides inconsistent provisions, including official-secrecy law, while the OSA remains in force; genuine protected interests must therefore be tested through RTI's exemption architecture.
- B. Privacy protects dignity, autonomy and contextual control over personal information, while transparency checks public power and expenditure; a sound decision identifies whose privacy, what public function and whether narrower disclosure can serve the interest.
- C. From 13 November 2025, the DPDP amendment substituted the RTI personal-information exemption with 'information which relates to personal information'; public-interest, severability and third-party provisions remain, requiring careful legal reasoning.
- D. Government possession does not create unlimited permission to circulate data; ethical information sharing should have lawful authority, a defined purpose, minimum necessary fields, accuracy, access control, retention limits, security and an auditable remedy route.

Answer: A

Explanation: Section 22 displaces inconsistent secrecy law without repealing it is the controlling principle. The RTI Act overrides inconsistent provisions, including official-secrecy law, while the OSA remains in force; genuine protected interests must therefore be tested through RTI's exemption architecture. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 42

An answer says Parliament repealed the OSA when enacting RTI. Which legal correction is required? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. From 13 November 2025, the DPDP amendment substituted the RTI personal-information exemption with 'information which relates to personal information'; public-interest, severability and third-party provisions remain, requiring careful legal reasoning.
- B. The RTI Act overrides inconsistent provisions, including official-secrecy law, while the OSA remains in force; genuine protected interests must therefore be tested through RTI's exemption architecture.
- C. Government possession does not create unlimited permission to circulate data; ethical information sharing should have lawful authority, a defined purpose, minimum necessary fields, accuracy, access control, retention limits, security and an auditable remedy route.
- D. Privacy protects dignity, autonomy and contextual control over personal information, while transparency checks public power and expenditure; a sound decision identifies whose privacy, what public function and whether narrower disclosure can serve the interest.

Answer: B

Explanation: Section 22 displaces inconsistent secrecy law without repealing it is the controlling principle. The RTI Act overrides inconsistent provisions, including official-secrecy law, while the OSA remains in force; genuine protected interests must therefore be tested through RTI's exemption architecture. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 43

A request seeks a public servant's unrelated medical details merely to attract attention. Which competing value requires serious weight? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The RTI Act overrides inconsistent provisions, including official-secrecy law, while the OSA remains in force; genuine protected interests must therefore be tested through RTI's exemption architecture.
- B. From 13 November 2025, the DPDP amendment substituted the RTI personal-information exemption with 'information which relates to personal information'; public-interest, severability and third-party provisions remain, requiring careful legal reasoning.
- C. Privacy protects dignity, autonomy and contextual control over personal information, while transparency checks public power and expenditure; a sound decision identifies whose privacy, what public function and whether narrower disclosure can serve the interest.
- D. Government possession does not create unlimited permission to circulate data; ethical information sharing should have lawful authority, a defined purpose, minimum necessary fields, accuracy, access control, retention limits, security and an auditable remedy route.

Answer: C

Explanation: Privacy and transparency protect different democratic goods is the controlling principle. Privacy protects dignity, autonomy and contextual control over personal information, while transparency checks public power and expenditure; a sound decision identifies whose privacy, what public function and whether narrower disclosure can serve the interest. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 44

A record of public expenditure includes beneficiary identifiers that can be masked without hiding aggregate delivery. Which balancing method is preferable? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. From 13 November 2025, the DPDP amendment substituted the RTI personal-information exemption with 'information which relates to personal information'; public-interest, severability and third-party provisions remain, requiring careful legal reasoning.
- B. Government possession does not create unlimited permission to circulate data; ethical information sharing should have lawful authority, a defined purpose, minimum necessary fields, accuracy, access control, retention limits, security and an auditable remedy route.
- C. The RTI Act overrides inconsistent provisions, including official-secrecy law, while the OSA remains in force; genuine protected interests must therefore be tested through RTI's exemption architecture.
- D. Privacy protects dignity, autonomy and contextual control over personal information, while transparency checks public power and expenditure; a sound decision identifies whose privacy, what public function and whether narrower disclosure can serve the interest.

Answer: D

Explanation: Privacy and transparency protect different democratic goods is the controlling principle. Privacy protects dignity, autonomy and contextual control over personal information, while transparency checks public power and expenditure; a sound decision identifies whose privacy, what public function and whether narrower disclosure can serve the interest. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 45

A current answer reproduces only the former public-activity and larger-public-interest wording of clause (j). Which date-stamped correction is necessary? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. From 13 November 2025, the DPDP amendment substituted the RTI personal-information exemption with 'information which relates to personal information'; public-interest, severability and third-party provisions remain, requiring careful legal reasoning.
- B. The RTI Act overrides inconsistent provisions, including official-secrecy law, while the OSA remains in force; genuine protected interests must therefore be tested through RTI's exemption architecture.
- C. Privacy protects dignity, autonomy and contextual control over personal information, while transparency checks public power and expenditure; a sound decision identifies whose privacy, what public function and whether narrower disclosure can serve the interest.
- D. Government possession does not create unlimited permission to circulate data; ethical information sharing should have lawful authority, a defined purpose, minimum necessary fields, accuracy, access control, retention limits, security and an auditable remedy route.

Answer: A

Explanation: DPDP Section 44(3) changed the text of RTI Section 8(1)(j) is the controlling principle. From 13 November 2025, the DPDP amendment substituted the RTI personal-information exemption with 'information which relates to personal information'; public-interest, severability and third-party provisions remain, requiring careful legal reasoning. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 46

A candidate says the substitution repealed every other RTI balancing and procedural provision. Which surviving architecture disproves the claim? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Privacy protects dignity, autonomy and contextual control over personal information, while transparency checks public power and expenditure; a sound decision identifies whose privacy, what public function and whether narrower disclosure can serve the interest.
- B. From 13 November 2025, the DPDP amendment substituted the RTI personal-information exemption with 'information which relates to personal information'; public-interest, severability and third-party provisions remain, requiring careful legal reasoning.
- C. Government possession does not create unlimited permission to circulate data; ethical information sharing should have lawful authority, a defined purpose, minimum necessary fields, accuracy, access control, retention limits, security and an auditable remedy route.
- D. The RTI Act overrides inconsistent provisions, including official-secrecy law, while the OSA remains in force; genuine protected interests must therefore be tested through RTI's exemption architecture.

Answer: B

Explanation: DPDP Section 44(3) changed the text of RTI Section 8(1)(j) is the controlling principle. From 13 November 2025, the DPDP amendment substituted the RTI personal-information exemption with 'information which relates to personal information'; public-interest, severability and third-party provisions remain, requiring careful legal reasoning. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 47

A welfare database is copied to an unrelated publicity unit because both belong to government. Which information-sharing safeguard fails first? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The RTI Act overrides inconsistent provisions, including official-secrecy law, while the OSA remains in force; genuine protected interests must therefore be tested through RTI's exemption architecture.
- B. Privacy protects dignity, autonomy and contextual control over personal information, while transparency checks public power and expenditure; a sound decision identifies whose privacy, what public function and whether narrower disclosure can serve the interest.
- C. Government possession does not create unlimited permission to circulate data; ethical information sharing should have lawful authority, a defined purpose, minimum necessary fields, accuracy, access control, retention limits, security and an auditable remedy route.
- D. From 13 November 2025, the DPDP amendment substituted the RTI personal-information exemption with 'information which relates to personal information'; public-interest, severability and third-party provisions remain, requiring careful legal reasoning.

Answer: C

Explanation: Purpose limitation governs inter-departmental sharing is the controlling principle. Government possession does not create unlimited permission to circulate data; ethical information sharing should have lawful authority, a defined purpose, minimum necessary fields, accuracy, access control, retention limits, security and an auditable remedy route. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 48

Two agencies share verified minimum fields under a recorded legal purpose with access logs and correction. Which governance model is demonstrated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Privacy protects dignity, autonomy and contextual control over personal information, while transparency checks public power and expenditure; a sound decision identifies whose privacy, what public function and whether narrower disclosure can serve the interest.
- B. From 13 November 2025, the DPDP amendment substituted the RTI personal-information exemption with 'information which relates to personal information'; public-interest, severability and third-party provisions remain, requiring careful legal reasoning.
- C. The RTI Act overrides inconsistent provisions, including official-secrecy law, while the OSA remains in force; genuine protected interests must therefore be tested through RTI's exemption architecture.
- D. Government possession does not create unlimited permission to circulate data; ethical information sharing should have lawful authority, a defined purpose, minimum necessary fields, accuracy, access control, retention limits, security and an auditable remedy route.

Answer: D

Explanation: Purpose limitation governs inter-departmental sharing is the controlling principle. Government possession does not create unlimited permission to circulate data; ethical information sharing should have lawful authority, a defined purpose, minimum necessary fields, accuracy, access control, retention limits, security and an auditable remedy route. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Solved PYQ 1 - 2018 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q2(a): What is meant by public interest? What are the principles and procedures to be followed by the civil servants in public interest? (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact isolated subpart verified against books\more_previous_papers\GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER-IV.pdf, page 2. Topic 09 is the primary public-service-values owner; Topic 15 uses it only for disclosure balancing.

Model solution

Public interest is constitutionally permissible common welfare assessed through evidence, rights and fair distribution, not the preference of an official, a powerful group or a bare numerical majority. It includes vulnerable, remote and future citizens who may lack an effective voice.

A civil servant should first identify lawful authority and the affected interests. She should collect relevant facts, disclose material conflicts, consult affected groups where feasible, compare less restrictive alternatives, apply objective criteria and record reasons. Equality, dignity, proportionality, economy and long-term effects should guide the choice. Transparency requires publication of non-sensitive criteria and outcomes; privacy or security restrictions must be specific and no wider than necessary. An appeal or review route should correct exclusion.

For example, releasing a village-wise relief list may expose diversion, but unnecessary medical details should be masked. Public interest therefore does not mean maximum disclosure or maximum secrecy. It is a reasoned constitutional judgment whose evidence, procedure and balance are capable of scrutiny.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2018 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q2(b): "The Right to Information Act is not all about citizens' empowerment alone, it essentially redefines the concept of accountability." Discuss. (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact isolated subpart verified against books\more_previous_papers\GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER-IV.pdf, page 2. This is Topic 15's direct historical PYQ.

Model solution

RTI empowers a citizen to seek existing records, but its deeper contribution is to change the relationship between public authority and citizen. Section 4 requires organised records and proactive disclosure; Sections 6 and 7 create a time-bound request route; Section 19 supplies appeal; and Section 20 can attach personal consequence to specified PIO failures. The authority, rather than the applicant, must justify withholding under a statutory exemption.

This makes decisions traceable. Tender criteria, beneficiary lists, expenditure and recorded reasons can be compared with law and actual delivery. MKSS-style verification of muster rolls illustrates how information becomes evidence for social accountability. Yet disclosure alone is not complete accountability: a competent forum must hear, judge, correct and remedy the revealed failure.

Privacy, security and other protected interests also require narrow, reasoned treatment, including severability. RTI therefore redefines accountability by moving administration from discretionary secrecy toward documented answerability, while remaining one component of a wider audit, grievance and remedial system.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2018 - 20 marks

Question: GS-IV Q12: Edward Snowden, a computer expert and former CIA systems administrator, released confidential Government documents to the press about the existence of Government surveillance programmes. According to many legal experts and the US Government, his actions violated the Espionage Act of 1917, which identified the leak of State secrets as an act of treason. Yet, despite the fact that he broke the law, Snowden argued that he had a moral obligation to act. He gave a justification for his "whistle blowing" by stating that he had a duty "to inform the public as to that which is done in their name and that which is done against them." According to Snowden, the Government's violation of privacy had to be exposed regardless of legality since more substantive issues of social action and public morality were involved here. Many agreed with Snowden. Few argued that he broke the law and compromised national security, for which he should be held accountable. Do you agree that Snowden's actions were ethically justified even if legally prohibited? Why or why not? Make an argument by weighing the competing values in this case. (Answer in 250 words)

Source / ownership: Exact full case verified against books\more_previous_papers\GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER-IV.pdf, page 11. Topic 10 and Topic 22 own conscience and full case method; Topic 15 owns the disclosure-secrecy-privacy boundary. The stem's legal characterisations are not independently asserted as settled conclusions.

Model solution

The case opposes privacy, informed democratic consent and exposure of possible abuse to legality, official confidentiality, institutional loyalty and national security. A disclosure is not ethical merely because the discloser invokes conscience; nor does classification automatically defeat a serious public-interest claim.

The decision should test the gravity and evidence of the alleged wrong, the availability and safety of internal or independent oversight channels, necessity of external disclosure, reliability of the material, and proportionality of what is revealed. Information unrelated to the wrongdoing should be minimised or redacted. Consequentialism weighs democratic correction against operational and personal harm; duty ethics recognises duties of truth and confidentiality; virtue ethics requires courage joined with prudence.

For an Indian administrator, the normal route is to preserve evidence, record objection and use competent vigilance, legislative, judicial or protected-reporting channels. External disclosure becomes morally stronger where grave illegality is evidenced, ordinary remedies are ineffective and release is narrowly tailored. The defensible verdict is therefore conditional: exposing unlawful surveillance may serve public morality, but indiscriminate publication that creates avoidable security or privacy harm remains unjustified. Independent review and severability offer the best reconciliation.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2019 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q4(b): There is a view that the Official Secrets Act is an obstacle to the implementation of Right to Information Act. Do you agree with the view? Discuss. (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact isolated subpart verified against books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM19-GeneralStudies-IV.pdf, page 3. This is Topic 15's direct PYQ; Citizens' Charter in Q4(a) is excluded.

Model solution

The view is substantially persuasive as an administrative-culture critique, but it needs a legal qualification. The Official Secrets Act, 1923 remains in force and can reinforce classification, fear of disclosure and a colonial need-to-know mindset. The Second ARC therefore recommended its repeal and relocation of genuine secrecy offences into a national-security law.

Legally, however, OSA is not an automatic answer to an RTI request. Section 22 gives the RTI Act overriding effect to the extent of inconsistency. Withholding must be justified through a relevant RTI exemption, while Section 8(2) permits disclosure where public interest outweighs harm. Section 10 requires release of a reasonably severable non-exempt part.

National security, protected sources and operational details can require secrecy; transparency does not mean indiscriminate release. Reform should narrow classification, record reasons, review secrecy periodically, train PIOs and strengthen independent appeal. Thus the chief obstacle is not coexistence alone but using the OSA label to bypass RTI's clause-specific, harm-based and reviewable architecture.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2019 - 20 marks

Question: GS-IV Q12: In recent times, there has been an increasing concern in India to develop effective civil service ethics, codes of conduct, transparency measures, ethics and integrity systems and anti-corruption agencies. In view of this, there is a need being felt to focus on three specific areas, which are directly relevant to the problems of internalizing integrity and ethics in the civil services. These are as follows: 1. Anticipating specific threats to ethical standards and integrity in the civil services, 2. Strengthening the ethical competence of civil servants and 3. Developing administrative processes and practices which promote ethical values and integrity in civil services. Suggest institutional measures to address the above three issues. (Answer in 250 words)

Source / ownership: Faithful English text and numbering verified against books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM19-GeneralStudies-IV.pdf, page 7. Topic 16/20 own the full ethics-system demand; Topic 15 contributes transparency and information architecture.

Model solution

The three demands require a prevention-capability-process architecture. First, departments should map risks around procurement, transfers, licensing, data access and conflicts of interest. Published criteria, rotation in sensitive posts, conflict registers, electronic audit trails, protected reporting and risk-based vigilance can expose threats before loss occurs.

Second, ethical competence needs induction and recurring dilemma-based training, confidential ethics advice, mentoring and leadership by example. Officers should practise giving speaking reasons, balancing RTI with privacy, managing conflicts and using lawful dissent channels. Training should be evaluated through decisions and institutional outcomes, not attendance.

Third, processes should reduce opaque discretion: Section 4-style proactive disclosure, accessible service standards, e-procurement, reasoned orders, record-retention rules, independent audit, time-bound appeal and grievance remedy. Information systems must show decision ownership without exposing protected personal or security data. Social audit can compare official records with delivery where the function permits citizen verification.

No agency alone can manufacture integrity. Excessive surveillance may chill honest judgment, while publication without correction becomes theatre. Controls should therefore be proportionate, protect documented good faith and link disclosure to a competent forum, remedy and learning. Ethical culture becomes durable when character is

supported by reviewable institutional design.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2021 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q6(a): An independent and empowered social audit mechanism is an absolute must in every sphere of public service, including judiciary, to ensure performance, accountability and ethical conduct. Elaborate. (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact isolated subpart verified against books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM-21-GENSTUDIESPAPER-IV-110122.pdf, page 3. Topic 11 is primary; Topic 15 supplies the records-and-disclosure precondition.

Model solution

Social audit enables citizens to compare official records with lived delivery. Independence from the implementing body, proactive access to intelligible records, field verification and a public hearing can expose ghost entries, exclusion and poor performance hidden by aggregate reports. MGNREGA workers, for example, may compare job cards, muster rolls, wages and completed works.

Information is necessary but insufficient. Empowerment requires a time-bound action-taken report, correction or compensation, recovery or disciplinary referral where evidence supports it, reasoned rejection of unsupported claims and protection against intimidation. Privacy-sensitive identifiers should be minimised or masked where public verification does not require them.

The phrase 'every sphere' must be functionally adapted. Citizen scrutiny of court administration cannot become crowd control of adjudication; decisional independence, confidentiality and lawful appeal remain. Social audit complements CAG, departmental audit and courts. Its ethical value lies in converting usable disclosure into participatory verification and enforceable follow-up.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2024 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q5(a): The 'Code of Conduct' and 'Code of Ethics' are the sources of guidance in public administration. There is code of conduct already in operation, whereas code of ethics is not yet put in place. Suggest a suitable model for code of ethics to maintain integrity, probity and transparency in governance. (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact isolated subpart verified against books\mains\05 UPSC 2024 Paper-IV_Final 1.pdf, page 3. Topic 16 is primary; Topic 15 contributes openness, information-use and review.

Model solution

A Code of Ethics should begin with constitutional fidelity and public purpose, then state selflessness, integrity, merit objectivity, impartiality, openness, honest interest declaration, accountability and leadership by example. Its transparency chapter should require publication of decision criteria, speaking reasons, accurate records, lawful RTI assistance and responsible use of confidential and personal information.

Implementation matters more than a declaration. Officers need dilemma training, confidential ethics advice, interest registers, recusal protocols, secure reporting, independent complaint handling, fair inquiry and an annual account of observance. Proactive disclosure should be current and intelligible, while privacy, security and fiduciary limits are applied through stated law rather than generic secrecy.

A Code of Conduct remains complementary because it specifies prohibited behaviour, procedures and consequences. Neither code can replace the RTI Act, service rules or due process. The suitable model therefore joins values with records, institutional advice, review and remedy, making claimed ethical standards visible without treating maximum publicity as maximum probity.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 8 - 2025 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q1(b): "Constitutional morality is not a natural sentiment but a product of civil education and adherence of the rule of law." Examine the significance of constitutional morality for public servant highlighting the role in promoting good governance and ensuring accountability in public administration. (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact English wording, including the printed 'adherence', verified against books\mains\UPSC Mains 2025 GS Paper 4.pdf, page 2. Topic 10/14 are primary; Topic 15 uses the public-reasons and accountability cross-link.

Model solution

Constitutional morality is learned fidelity to constitutional values, procedures and limits on power rather than obedience to private preference or a temporary majority. For a public servant it turns equality, dignity, liberty and rule of law into daily decision standards.

It promotes good governance by requiring lawful competence, objective criteria, fair hearing, public reasons and review. These disciplines restrain arbitrary discretion and protect minorities even where local prejudice is popular. Accountability improves because a decision leaves a record that citizens, auditors and appellate bodies can test. A district officer allocating relief should publish need-based criteria, record exclusions, protect unnecessary personal data and provide a grievance route.

Constitutional morality is not mechanical publicity or rule worship. Sensitive information may be withheld under law, and humane discretion may be needed, but both require proportionate reasons and review. It thus makes transparency purposeful: information enables citizens to examine whether public power remained within constitutional values and to obtain correction when it did not.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 9 - 2025 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q6(b): India is an emerging economic power of the world as it has recently secured the status of fourth largest economy of the world as per IMF projection. However, it has been observed that in some sectors, allocated funds remain either underutilised or misutilised. What specific measures would you recommend for ensuring accountability in this regard to stop leakages and gaining the status of third largest economy of the world in near future? (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Wording verified from books\mains\UPSC Mains 2025 GS Paper 4.pdf, pages 3-4; the scan's text layer drops part of one printed line. Topic 18 is primary and Topic 11 owns general accountability; Topic 15 supplies disclosure and information-system measures.

Model solution

Public-fund accountability begins by naming responsibility for sanction, release, utilisation, output and outcome. Each budget head should have realistic milestones, interoperable expenditure records and a reviewing officer.

E-procurement, time-stamped transaction trails and exception alerts can identify idle balances, duplicate payments and delay.

Visibility must reach citizens and competent forums. Departments should proactively publish scheme-wise allocations, releases, physical progress, utilisation and audit responses in accessible, machine-readable form, subject to legitimate redaction. CAG and legislative scrutiny, field verification, social audit and protected complaints should test the data. Deviations require speaking explanations, time-bound correction, recovery or disciplinary referral where evidence supports it, and restoration of affected service.

Dashboards alone may contain poor or strategically reported data. Independent verification, data-quality responsibility, grievance appeal and outcome evaluation are essential. Information sharing across treasury, procurement and implementing units should be purpose-bound and secure. Thus transparency supports growth only when it matures into answerability, judgment and remedy.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Original Mains Practice 1 - 10 marks

Question: Distinguish transparency, disclosure, information sharing and accountability in public administration. Answer in about 150 words.

Model solution

Transparency is the continuing visibility of rules, criteria, reasons, records and outcomes to appropriate scrutiny. Disclosure is a particular act of releasing specified information, proactively or on request. Information sharing is the authorised movement of information for a defined function; it may occur between departments without becoming public. Accountability is the relationship in which an identified actor explains conduct against a standard before a competent forum capable of correction, remedy or consequence.

The distinctions are practical. Publishing a tender is disclosure and may strengthen transparency. Sharing verified bidder debarment data with another authorised buyer is purpose-bound information sharing. If an audit body examines the award, hears the officer and orders correction, accountability is completed. Conversely, a data dump without reasons may disclose much while remaining opaque.

Privacy and security qualify each process: public access may require redaction, while restricted sharing needs lawful purpose, minimum fields and access controls. Therefore transparency supplies visibility, disclosure and sharing move information, and accountability converts relevant information into answerable and correctable public power.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 2 - 10 marks

Question: Why is Section 4 proactive disclosure ethically superior to excessive dependence on individual RTI applications? Answer in about 150 words.

Model solution

Section 4 places the burden of routine openness on the public authority rather than on a citizen who must know what to ask, draft an application and pursue delay. Organised records and regular publication of functions, norms, budgets, subsidies, concessions and decision processes reduce information asymmetry before suspicion or litigation arises.

Proactive disclosure promotes equality because persons with less legal literacy, money or time gain the same baseline information. It also reduces repetitive applications and PIO workload, supports media and social audit, and disciplines officials who know that criteria and outcomes will be visible. Publishing ward-wise works and expenditure, for example, lets residents compare records with the site.

Its ethical superiority is conditional. Obsolete links, scanned dumps and unexplained datasets create compliance theatre; personal data and genuine security interests require lawful protection. Authorities should therefore publish current, searchable, accessible and machine-readable material with metadata, review dates and grievance routes. Individual RTI remains necessary for file-specific records. Section 4 is the first channel, not a substitute for request, appeal and remedy.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 3 - 15 marks

Question: Examine how Sections 8(2), 10 and 11 prevent both absolute secrecy and reckless disclosure under the RTI Act. Answer in about 200 words.

Model solution

The RTI Act does not choose between disclosure of everything and secrecy by label. Section 8(1) protects specified interests, but Section 8(2) permits access where public interest in disclosure outweighs harm to those interests, notwithstanding the Official Secrets Act or the listed exemptions. The authority must therefore identify the protected harm and weigh it against a concrete public benefit.

Section 10 narrows withholding. If protected names, coordinates or trade details can reasonably be separated, the remainder must be supplied with reasons and review information. It prevents one exempt sentence from concealing an entire report. Section 11 adds procedural fairness where confidential third-party material may be released: notice and representation inform the PIO's decision, but objection is not an absolute veto.

Consider a completed public-works contract containing a proprietary technique and evidence of inflated payment. The PIO should hear the contractor, protect genuinely competitive material, sever it where possible and assess public interest in expenditure disclosure. The applicant and third party retain appeal rights.

These provisions demand reasoned calibration. Section 8(2) is not a magic phrase, severability must be practicable, and consultation must not outsource the statutory decision. Together they make secrecy exceptional, disclosure proportionate and the process reviewable.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 4 - 15 marks

Question: Assess the institutional-independence implications of the RTI (Amendment) Act, 2019 without overstating its effect. Answer in about 200 words.

Model solution

Before 2019, the RTI Act itself fixed the tenure of the Chief Information Commissioner and Information Commissioners and linked their salaries to specified constitutional or senior offices. The Amendment changed Sections 13 and 16 so that tenure, salary, allowances and service conditions for Central and State Commissions are prescribed by the Central Government. The 2019 Rules, not the Amendment's text, prescribe a three-year term subject to the age ceiling.

The ethical concern is structural. Information Commissions decide appeals involving public authorities, including governments. Moving safeguards from Parliament-fixed text to executive rules can reduce the appearance or durability of insulation and may create a chilling-risk argument. Central prescription for State commissioners also raises a federal-design concern.

However, the Amendment did not abolish the citizen's right, exemptions, appeals or penalty power, and a rule-making change does not prove actual interference in any decision. Administrative uniformity and flexibility are legitimate counterclaims. Independence also depends on transparent appointments, vacancies, resources, reasoned orders and review, not tenure alone.

A balanced reform would place core tenure and remuneration safeguards in statute, ensure timely merit-based appointments and publish performance information while preserving adjudicatory autonomy. The defensible conclusion is a serious institutional-design concern, not an allegation of established misconduct.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 5 - 20 marks

Question: Privacy is not an exemption from accountability, and transparency is not a licence for personal-data exposure. Discuss after Puttaswamy and the DPDP-driven amendment to RTI Section 8(1)(j). Answer in about 250 words.

Model solution

Privacy and transparency protect different constitutional-democratic goods. Privacy preserves dignity, autonomy and contextual control over personal information; transparency exposes the exercise of public power and public money. Puttaswamy recognised privacy as a fundamental right, requiring State intrusion to rest on legality, legitimate aim, proportionality and safeguards. Yet public office cannot convert every service-related record into a private enclave.

DPDP Act Section 44(3), commenced on 13 November 2025, substituted RTI Section 8(1)(j) with the broader text 'information which relates to personal information'. A current answer must not reproduce the former clause as operative law. Equally, it should not claim that all balancing vanished: Section 8(2)'s public-interest override, Section 10 severability, Section 11 third-party procedure and appeal remain in the Act. How these provisions interact with the substituted clause may require authoritative adjudication; Section 8(2) should not be treated as automatically restoring every deleted phrase.

Administrators should ask: whose privacy is affected, what public function or expenditure is under scrutiny, what concrete harm follows, and can masking or aggregation serve accountability? Aggregate beneficiary delivery, tender evaluation and conflict information may often be disclosed without unrelated medical, family or identity details. Notice, reasoned redaction and appeal protect both sides.

As of 29 August 2026, the DPDP Act is not wholly operational: Section 44(3) is in force; Section 6(9) and Section 27(1)(d) commence on 13 November 2026; and many core processing, rights and penalty provisions commence on 13 May 2027. Ethical minimisation, security and purpose limitation remain prudent before full commencement. The correct approach is accountable privacy: disclose what tests public power, protect what needlessly exposes the person, and explain the legal balance.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 6 - 20 marks

Question: A State plans to link welfare, health and land databases to detect fraud and publish a district dashboard. As the responsible secretary, design an ethical information-sharing and transparency framework. Answer in about 250 words.

Model solution

The proposal can detect duplicate claims and improve planning, but it combines distinct purposes and creates exclusion, profiling, breach and function-creep risks. Stakeholders include genuine beneficiaries, wrongly flagged families, officials, local bodies, data processors, auditors and the public. I would not authorise unrestricted linkage or publication.

First, each exchange must identify legal authority, a specific fraud or planning purpose, necessary fields, data quality and a responsible officer. A documented sharing agreement should prohibit unrelated reuse, set role-based access, encryption, retention and deletion, preserve logs, require breach response and permit independent audit. High-risk matches should be treated as leads, never automatic grounds for benefit denial. Affected persons need notice where lawful, assisted correction, a speaking decision and prompt human appeal.

Second, the public dashboard should use aggregation and suppression thresholds so citizens can compare allocation, delivery, pendency and grievance outcomes without exposing names, diagnoses or precise land identifiers. Methodology, update date, limitations and responsible office should be published. File-level records remain available through RTI subject to exemptions, severability and third-party procedure.

Third, an oversight group including legal, security, programme and field expertise should test bias, false matches and access patterns. Periodic necessity review must terminate fields or linkages that do not improve the stated purpose. Procurement contracts should ensure portability and government audit access.

Puttaswamy supplies the legality and proportionality discipline; data ethics adds minimisation and purpose limitation. The framework therefore separates restricted sharing from public disclosure, and connects both to answerability, correction and remedy. Fraud control is legitimate only when the information system does not make an innocent citizen transparent to an unaccountable State.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.